



ITALY

Capital city: Rome**Area:** 116,305 sq miles
(301,230 sq km)**Population:** 57,400,000**Official language:** Italian**Major religion:** Christian
85% Muslim 2%, other
13%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Euro**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 78 years**People per doctor:** 233**Televisions:** 420 per
1,000 people

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ANCIENT TRADITIONS and historic wealth have left Italy a rich legacy of art and architecture. Although Italy is one of the world's leading industrial powers today, there is a great divide between the wealthy, industrial north and the poorer, agricultural south. This economic division affects many aspects of Italian life and is one of the reasons behind the country's rapid turnover of governments. Most people throughout Italy follow the Roman Catholic religion.

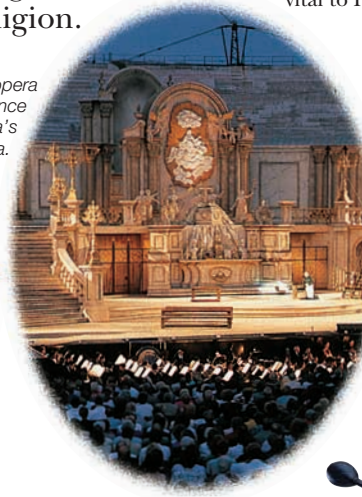


TOURISM

Some of the world's most stunning sights can be found in Italy's cities. Tourists flock to the ancient ruins of Rome and to the palaces and churches of Florence, where the great revolution in art known as the Renaissance was born in the 15th century. The northern ski resorts and lakes are also popular. Tourism is vital to Italy's economy.

Tall vines scramble up rows of posts and any available fruit trees.

An opera performance in Verona's Roman arena.



OPERA

The three great national passions are fast cars, soccer – and opera. Opera was virtually invented in Italy and performers such as Luciano Pavarotti are household names worldwide. Italian opera is unique in that it is a part of everyday life, and not just a pastime for the wealthy few, as it often is elsewhere.

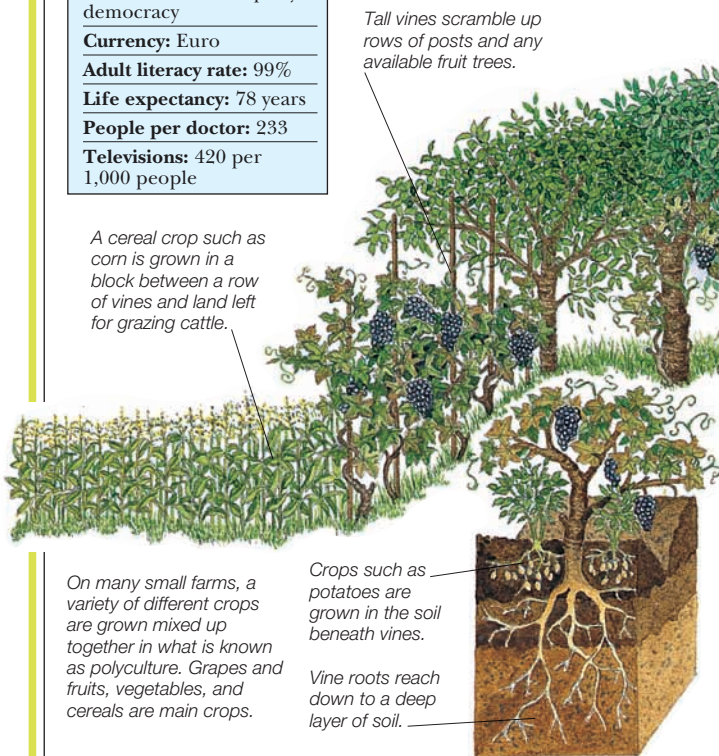
AGRICULTURE

Small, family-run farms cover the Italian countryside, and many farmers work part-time. In the fertile northern plain surrounding the Po River, small-scale farmers get the most from their land by growing a variety of different crops close together. Cereals, fruit trees, grapes, and vegetables are widely grown, and there are olive groves in the south. Italy is a leading producer of fruit, wine, and olive oil.



INDUSTRY

Once an agricultural nation, Italy is now a leading industrial country. Since it does not have many natural resources, Italy imports raw materials and uses its highly skilled workforce to turn them into manufactured goods, like the scooter shown here. Italy is a major player in industrial and product design, and fashion.



A cereal crop such as corn is grown in a block between a row of vines and land left for grazing cattle.

On many small farms, a variety of different crops are grown mixed up together in what is known as polyculture. Grapes and fruits, vegetables, and cereals are main crops.

Crops such as potatoes are grown in the soil beneath vines.

Vine roots reach down to a deep layer of soil.

The hard, strong-tasting Parmesan cheese is made from cow's milk in the north of Italy.



A popular meal is pasta with tomatoes, and often Parmesan cheese.



Tomatoes grow well in the warm sun around Naples.



Pasta comes in many shapes.

FAMILY MEALTIMES

To Italians, life revolves around the family, and large, extended networks of different generations usually live within close proximity. Meals are important family gatherings, and the food differs from region to region. In the north, pasta is often replaced by rice or polenta, made from corn flour. Olive oil and fresh vegetables are also important in Italian cooking.



A family enjoying a lunch together of pasta and fresh vegetables on the southern Italian island of Lipari.

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